UCR 5 YEAR ANNIVERSARY Health, Well-being & Safety

Leveraging social media analytics to assess student well-being and structural needs in a university setting

Ashish Kulkarni   Kritika Gupta, PhD   Denise Woods, DrPH

University of California, Riverside

Scan to explore the project dashboard

Why listen to public online discussion?

Students discuss academics, housing, social life, and basic needs online. Aggregated public posts may help identify topics for follow-up between surveys and administrative reporting.

Objectives: Identify recurring topics; describe posting and language-sentiment patterns; and explore whether place mentions can inform future assessment.

Study cohort

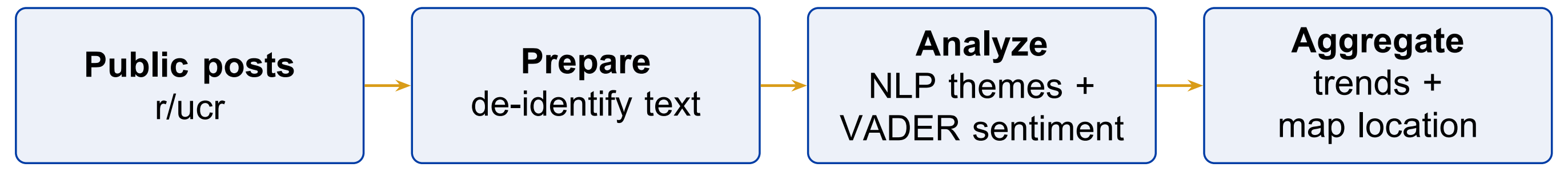
1,759

public r/ucr posts

Nov 18, 2025–Mar 31, 2026 • Mean VADER: **+20.7 / 100**

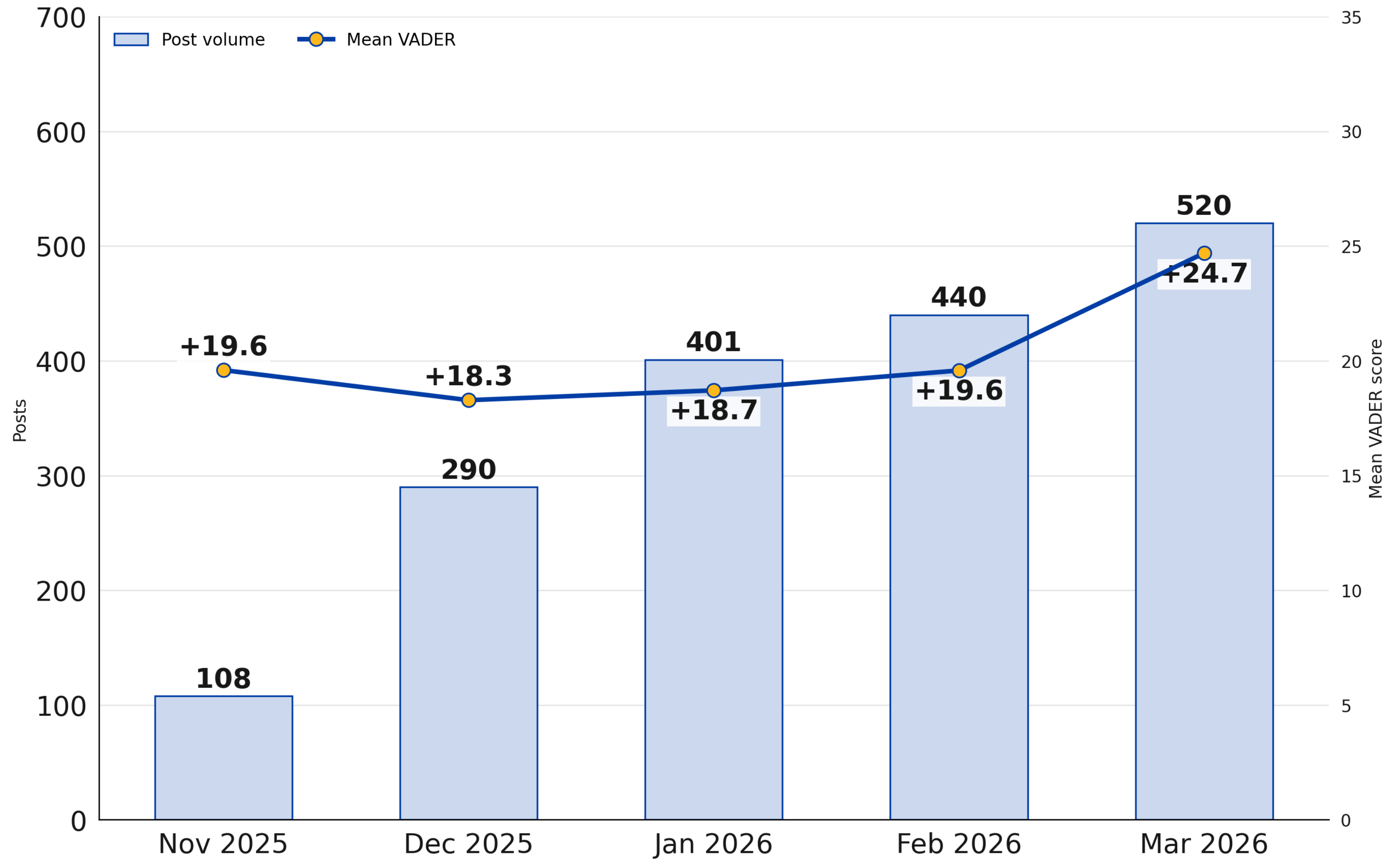
Study design and analytic workflow

Source: Public r/ucr posts from Nov. 18, 2025–Mar. 31, 2026. Quantitative analyses use each post's title and latest saved self-text; comments and media are excluded.



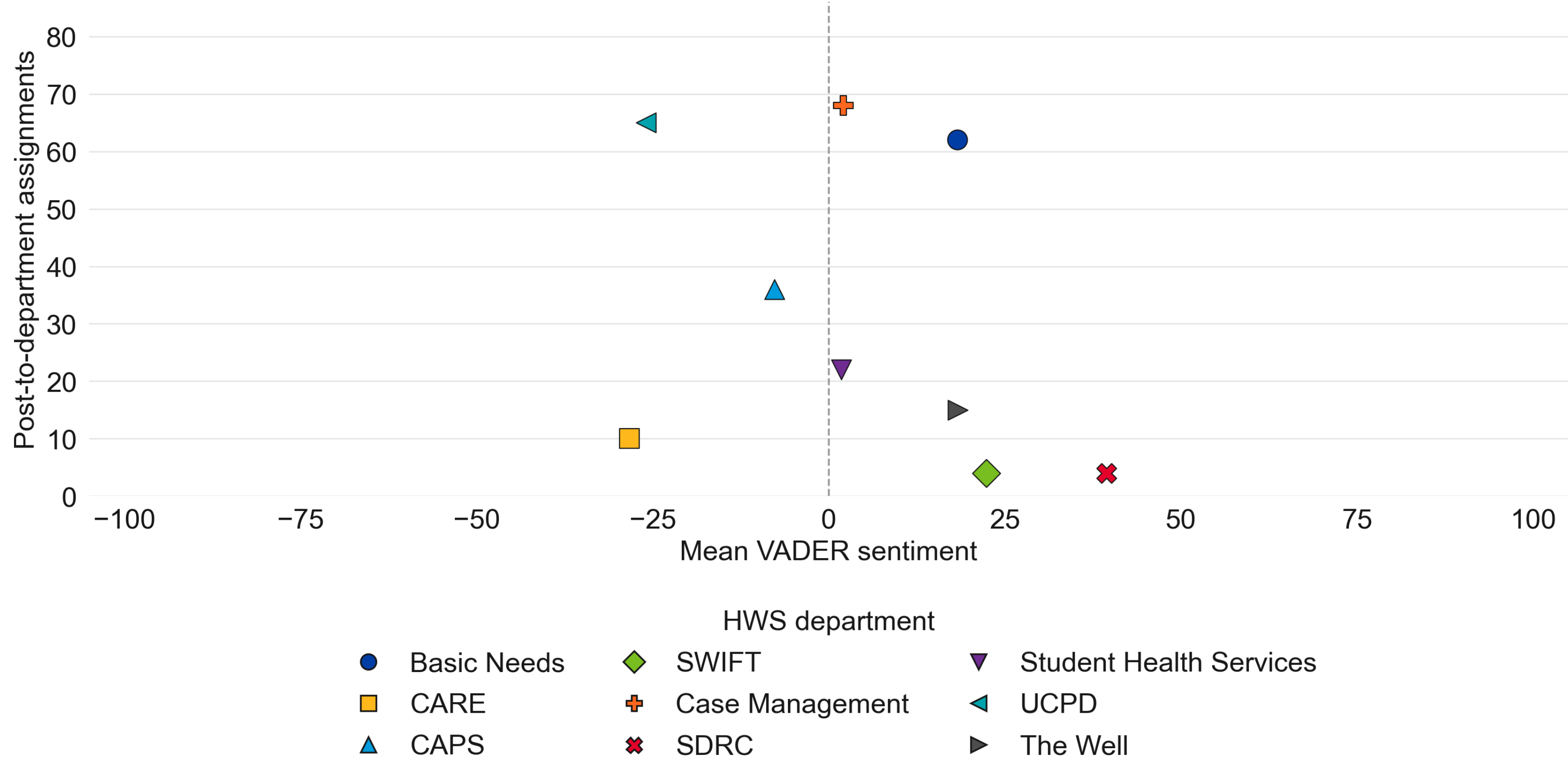
Public posts r/ucr → **Prepare** de-identify text → **Analyze** NLP themes + VADER sentiment → **Aggregate** trends + map location

Posting and sentiment trends



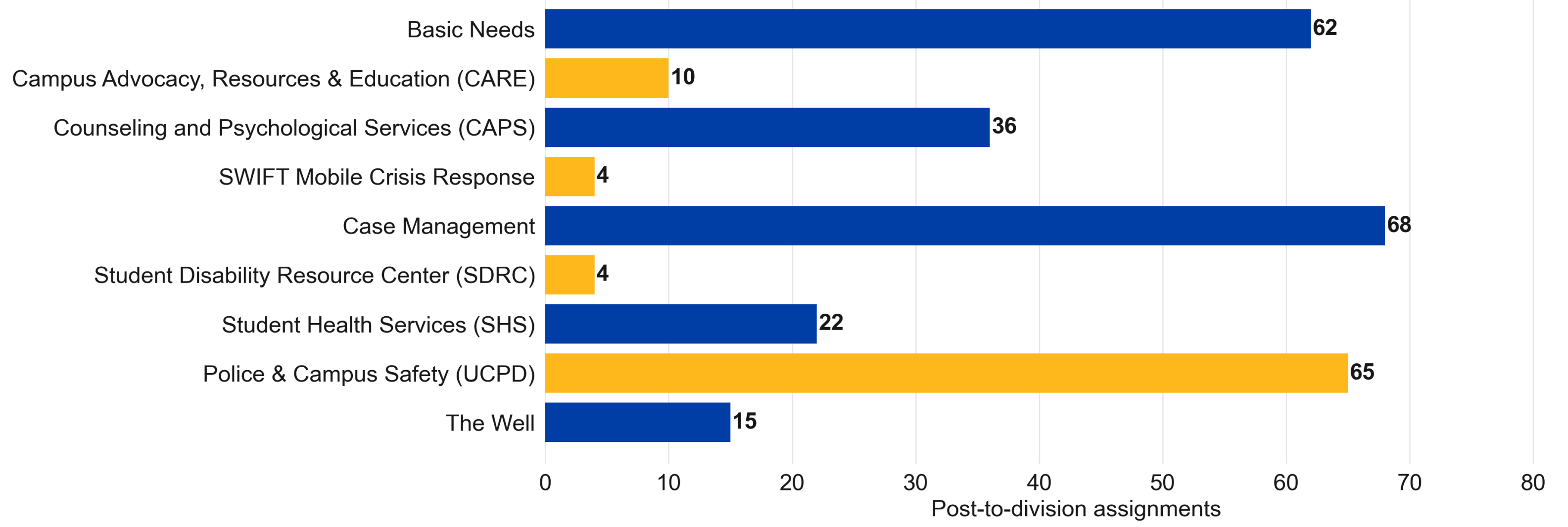
Monthly post volume rose over the studied timeframe. Mean monthly VADER scores ranged from +18.3 to +24.7. These descriptive patterns do not explain why posting or wording changed. The sentiment axis is scaled to observed monthly means; the full VADER range is −100 to +100.

HWS department volume × sentiment



Posts may map to multiple departments.

HWS department assignment split



209 posts received at least one HWS division tag and 67 received multiple tags. Bars count post-to-department assignments.

Post excerpts mapped to HWS departments

Mental health example

Title: I have no friends and I'm going insane

Post text: I'm not even a weird person or anything I had a pretty solid group freshman year that was highkey toxic as hell and just split apart. I joined some professional orgs on campus and I also work so I feel like I don't really have time to do rec clubs. Making friends in those 200 people lecture halls is practically insane...

Mapped departments: CAPS; The Well

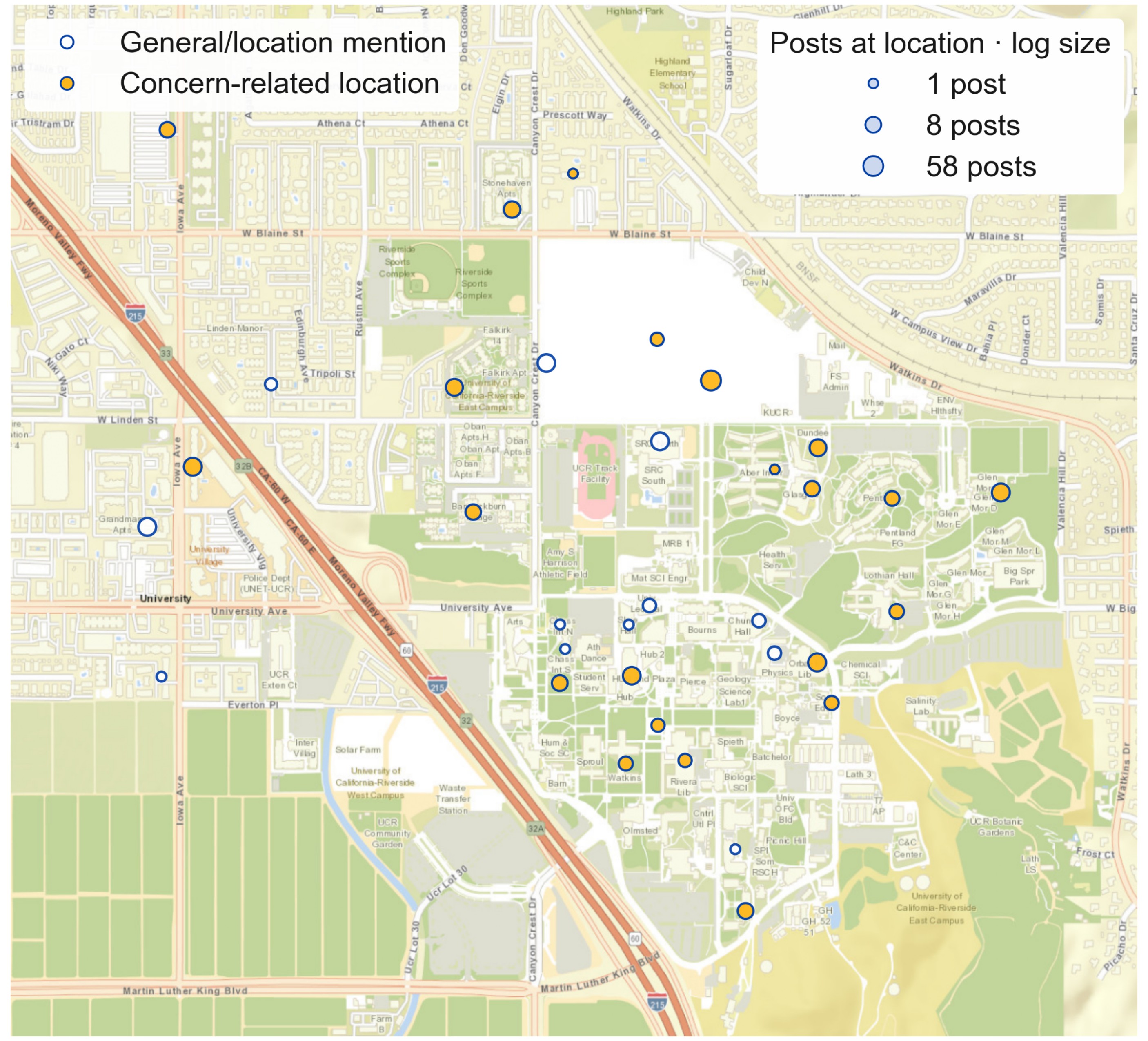
Campus safety example

Title: Someone just hit me with their scooter

Post text: Someone head on hit me while on their scooter, I was walking in a linear path looking down at an email.
After they hit me, they step off their scooter, and say "I was going on the right" and rode off. I said "my bad". If you're reading this, and you're the one who rammed me with your scooter outside of bcoe, I want you to know it WAS NOT my bad. It was your bad...

Mapped departments: Student Health Services (SHS); Police & Campus Safety (UCPD)

A new spatial lens: Esri campus map



Points show mapped place mentions. Marker size represents distinct posts at a location; color marks concern-related or general mentions.

Mapped mentions

The map shows 313 approved or auto-mapped post-location pairs across 34 coordinates. These are place mentions, not verified incidents. A post may map to more than one location.

Public health relevance and limitations

- Pair online signals with surveys and institutional data to identify topics for further assessment.
- Use place context to guide prevention and access questions; do not label people or places as unsafe.
- Reddit users are self-selected, and automated text and place matching can miss context or misclassify posts.
- Validate labels and co-design referral pathways with HWS and campus partners before operational use.

Privacy and responsible interpretation

- Observational use of public content; no user contact or attempt to identify people.
- Findings are aggregated for program assessment and referral, never individual profiling or discipline.
- Sentiment is a language proxy, not a measure of any student's mental health.

hwsresearch.ucr.edu   studentwellness.ucr.edu